কালীবাড়ি খবর

KALIBARI NEWS

(Registered Charity 1158269)
Visit us at: www.londonkalibari.org.uk

Kalibari Centre: 18 Byron Road, Wealdstone, Harrow, HA3 7ST
Issue 21, April 2019

From the Trustee Chairman

In this first Newsletter of 2019 I welcome you all and specially those who have recently returned from India after a long winter break and have given us impetus for the forthcoming events. In response to queries by members I wish to confirm the following. We have signed an extension of the lease for a further three years (first started in 2012) and so we stay in our current location until 28 September 2021. In our Monday Luncheon Club, all the food and other items such as tea, coffee, biscuits, milk and sweets are provided free by the members, and we charge a nominal £3 per person (some voluntarily pay more) which goes into Kalibari Building fund. Our standing expenditure for the lease and utilities is just over £700 per month. The income from donations, receipts from social functions, and Pujas (including Gift Aid refund of tax from HMRC) pays for this expenditure and adds to the Kalibari Building Fund about £12,000 per year.

For your information:
London Kalibari Trustees:
Dr Sudin Mandal (Chair), Mrs Jayati Das (Secretary), Mr Mrinal Choudhury (Treasurer), Mrs Krishna Ghosh, Mrs Debjani Sengupta and Dr Satya Chatterjee

Core Support Group:
Mrs Rama Choudhury, Mrs Gita Dutta, Mrs Babli Mazumdar, Mr Kanu Roy, Mr Snehangshu Basu, Mrs Giti Ray and Mrs Dipti Chatterjee

Do join us in all our forthcoming activities and make it a year of great success.

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General Secretary's Report:

We started our new year as the members returned after their winter break in various parts of the globe. The first celebration was Narayan Pujo on Sunday 24 March. We had about fifty devotees attending.

The resolution by Harrow Council to mark parts of both Byron Road and Oxford Road as restricted parking from Monday to Sunday till midnight is problematic for our senior members. On Puja day we collected about fifty signatures to petition against this parking restriction. Let us hope that they will heed our appeal.

Our next function is Kali Pujo on Sunday 5 May. If anybody wishes to hire Kalibari Centre for religious or social gatherings, they should contact our Treasurer Mr Mrinal Choudhury. We charge minimally to cover the overhead. The inside of the building has been painted by the Landlord – we have plans to upgrade the toilets.

Thank you for your continuing support.

Jai Ma Kali

Treasurer's Statement:

a) Income & Expenditure: (approximate - regular per month)

Income –	Standing Order	£270
	Lunch'n Club	£95*
	Donations	£30
	Hall Hire	£40
	Utsav/Events	£100
	Total	£535
Expenditure -	Rent	£600
	Utilities	£85
	Council Tax	£30 (Govt. Relief)
	Total	£715
Shortfall **		£195

* In the Luncheon club (every Monday), one member in turn donates the food and all contributions (nominally £3/head) from other members go to the fund

** Large donations make up the shortfall and leave a surplus for the Building Fund

b) Long term investment & Cash in bank – ask any trustee

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Cultural Secretary's Report

Welcome to our first newsletter, for the year 2019. Covering some late events of 2018, we must refer to our Annual Kali Pujo, held on 6th November. The Pujo was superbly conducted by Mr Amiya Bhattacharjee. Although a weekday, we had a record number of devotees from far afield, attending and appreciating. A joint Bijoya and Christmas Musical Evening, was held on 16th December, at Harrow Civic Centre. This event was presented by local artists Sandip Basu Mallick, Banu with Kakoli Sengupta from Paris, with dance by Esha Chakravarty and Sreeya Sengupta. There were talks by our members Sujit Bhattacharjee.and Parijat Bhattacharjee, and a recitation by Mrinal Choudhury. Guests were charmed and the evening brought to an end our eventful year, 2018.

Little did we anticipate the sad, sudden demise of our dear friend Kakoli Sengupta, on 4th January 2019. She will be sorely missed by her family, Kalibari friends and the numerous others she enchanted with her melodious voice. May 'Ma' rest her soul in peace. However, 2019 rolled in, as every other year does. Leaving behind a year that had its ups and downs. Wishes some achieved, some unfulfilled. Hope we will continue to have the support for our coming Kali Pujo, on Sunday, 5th May, at our Kalibari Centre. All other events will be publicised in our website londonkalibari.org. May Ma Bless you all.

Forthcoming Events 2018/19

- Kali Pujo: Sunday 5 May in Kalibari Centre (starting at 1pm- to be confirmed)
- Annual General Meeting : Sunday 14 July at Kalibari Centre (TBC)
- Main Kali Puja /Diwali: Sunday 27 October at Harrow Arts Centre
- Plans for a Narayan Puja and a Kalipuja between June and September.

London Kalibari wishes to thank the following:

1. Supporters and helpers from the Community.
2. Harrow Council for Accommodation and Rate Support.
3. Harrow Art Centre for Diwali/Kalipuja.
4. Mr Navin Shah, GLA Member, Wealdstone Labour Hall, for arranging the rental of the Kalibari Centre.
5. Mr Gareth Thomas, MP for Harrow West, Labour Party for his support.
6. Councillors of Harrow Council for their support and encouragement.
7. Sponsors of Kalibari events & activities.
8. Ms Tanuka Saha, of N. Saha & Co. Chartered Accountants.
9. Mr Avishek Chaudhuri for website.

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A Journey to the Kumbh Mela - Dr Satya Chatterjee

This winter we went to India for three months. After visiting Mount Abu in Rajasthan we took a tour in Madhya Pradesh and reached Kolkata 24 December.

Every morning I went down to my nephew ‘s flat to watch cricket, have tea and read the newspapers. One day I noticed a journal called ‘Udbodhan’ published by Ramakrishna Mission on the tea table. While browsing through it I saw an advertisement for the Kumbha Mela at Allahabad. Vivekananda Seva Samiti and Swami Abichalananda were arranging it, also there were pictures of Sri Ramakrishna and Ma Sarada Devi. There would be several dips (‘snan’) at auspicious times at the Sangam ie confluence of the river Ganges, Yamuna and Saraswati. The river Saraswati is incognito, it cannot be seen. People say that it is felt a few miles down the river from the meeting place of Ganga and Yamuna. I thought that it was organised by the Ramakrishna mission and there should be no problem. But the first ‘snan ‘ would be on the 15th January and I thought perhaps it was too late for going there. Hesitantly I asked my nephew if it would be possible to go to the Kumbha Mela. He immediately phoned the mobile number written on the advert. Abichal Maharaj answered and told that it would be possible, just send the fees and be there in good time. After a while Dipti, my beloved wife, came downstairs. When I disclosed that I was planning to go to Kumbha Mela she instantly started shouting and screaming saying I could not go because I am old, not physically fit, it is very cold there and I may get pneumonia and moreover we were so tired after our last tour. I thought my dream was ending there unless some miracle happened and she agreed. Our next door neighbour Bipasha on hearing that said, “why Kakima (auntie) let him go, there will be so many Holy men & Sadhus, Naga Sanyasi, you get blessing and your sins are absolved“. Dipti said that she did not believe that by dipping in water sins are washed away. The next day late afternoon we went to visit my elder sister who is BA Kabyatirtha in Sanskrit & President of local Ramakrishna Sangha. Hearing that I was planning to go to Kumbha Mela she became very happy and firmly told Dipti to accompany me. Also she reminded her that husband & wife should visit the Holy places together to have more ‘ Punya‘ (salvation).

She asked if we knew about Kumbha. I told as far as I remembered in the mythology, the Demons and Deity Gods & Goddesses decided to churn the Ocean to bring up precious things. They decided the mountain Mainak to be the stick and the great snake Basuki to be the rope. At the end of churning the Kumbha (Urn or Pitcher) containing the Nectar which makes one immortal, came up. The king of the Deity Gods, Indra’s son, snatched it and ran away. While running some of the nectar spilled and fell on 4 places, Haridwar, Nashik, Ujjaini and Allahabad. People and Holy men gather there to dip in the river. Every 12 years Purna Kumbha and every 3 years Ardha Kumbha at one of the places.

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(continued from page 4)

So we decided to go to Kumbha Mela together and requested someone to buy rail tickets. We paid the fees through Bank transfer as instructed by Abichal Maharaj. We planned to reach Allahabad on 12th and leave on 17th. Next day when we received the train tickets we found that going out on 11th evening our seats were both on upper berth and the return was not confirmed. Dipti said that she couldn't climb up for her bad knees and all tickets must be confirmed. So there was a problem!

Next day we went to Dumdum station and cancelled the tickets. We then went to Fairly Place and to the counter for foreign travellers. We were booked on a fast express train, one upper & one lower berth, same side (costing more) and were advised to go next door to buy return tickets in Senior Citizen's quota. This we did. In the meantime we thought to visit our niece at Lucknow The lady gave us return tickets for two lower berths in a Sleeping Compartment dated 19th. We thought to travel by taxi from Allahabad to Lucknow. We were happy. There were several days to pack. When others came to know that our return tickets were not AC 2 tier but non-AC sleeping coach, they warned us that people just come in the coach and sit and push themselves in and you cannot do anything about it, so change them immediately. But we were fed up and exhausted, we decided to go to Lucknow and then decide what to do next.

On 11th evening we went to Howrah station and got into our coach. We saw to our surprise that all the seats were occupied. I wondered if we were in the right coach. I went outside and found that it was the right number. Again I came in and showed our tickets to some passengers, some did not say anything but one young man pointed to our seats. Two men in their forties, seemed to be regular travellers businessmen perhaps did not speak Bengali, were sitting on our lower berth and eating puri sabji evening meal. When I showed our tickets they said they would go when they finish their meal. We had to stand quietly for sometime until they went.

Then we sat on the lower berth for a while. The train had already started moving. After sometime I got up and made our beds with supplied blankets and bedsheets. I was sitting and waiting to get up on the upper berth. There was a man also in his forties sitting opposite on the lower berth. He was a merchant from Banaras, selling silk saris & materials in Kolkata, a regular traveller. He offered his lower berth to Dipti and took our upper berth without any hesitation. He showed us products of his factory and pictures of his family on his mobile.

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On the 12th at about 1 pm we reached Allahabad station. We had to go to the other side by crossing over on the footbridge. We were supposed to take an auto to go to the Kumbha Mela area but at the auto stand I noticed that in our lane autos were not coming but they were coming on another lane about 15 yards away. People were waiting there, mostly local, running to the auto and putting their luggage and going away. Dipti went to some ' Totos which are run by electric battery, but they wouldn't take us. The Uber taxi wouldn't take us as they were pre booked.

Someone told us to go back to other side of the station for the taxis- which we did. There was an auto standing nearby and a few policemen were sitting inside a shed and the driver was sleeping inside his car. We requested the police for that auto. They came out and one of them pushed the driver to wake him up. After a while he got up, seemed drunk, but he did not want to drive us. I was thinking what was the catch! Then suddenly I realised that a young man standing there was controlling their movement. I went to the young man and told him politely that we were standing in the sun for over one hour and we were late going to the Kumbha Mela site. He took pity on us and said ' Sir next auto I will get for you '.

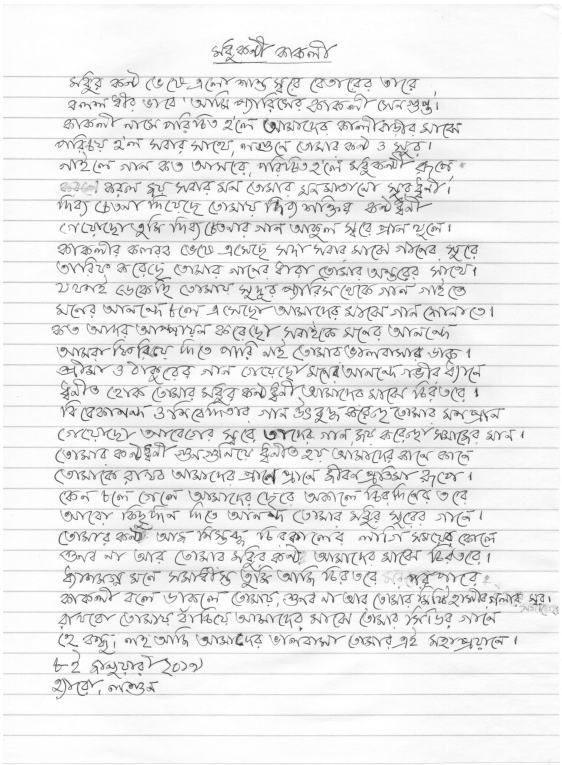
At last we got an auto and started for the great place. After about 30 minutes we reached a junction of about 3 - 4 roads and there was chaos. One jeep banged a car, our driver hit a scooter. Driver and people were shouting and there was a bad traffic jam. Anyway our driver managed to come out of the place and went forward to the riverside. He went on a specific road which led onto a long 'pontoon' bridge, then to other side of the river Ganga. There were about 20 such temporary bridges on the large bank of the river, about half dried all sandy, the place being about 32 kilometres square. Roads were made with iron planks of about 5ft by 15ft in 4 rows side by side layed for cars to travel. If any wheel goes out of that iron plank it may easily sink in the sand.

We could not find our place and I phoned Abichal Maharaj who asked us to come under the railway bridge and look for the camp. We were going round and round for over 1 hour but could not find the place. Someone told me that there was a big camp of Ramakrishna mission a few minutes drive on another road. Roads are called 'marg', ours' was Tulsi Marg. We went to the Ramakrishna mission - there were huge tents, well organised, but on a different marg. I told Swamiji that we were going round for one and half hours, people we asked did not know Abichal Maharaj & Vivekananda Samiti. He took pity on us and told us that Abichal Maharaj was not with Ramakrishna mission but with some other ' Akhra '. He phoned Abichal Maharaj and asked him to send some one to collect us.

(To be continued in the next issue of the Newsletter)

Kakoli Sengupta – A poem by Mrinal Choudhury

Kakoli lived in Paris and for the last six years has been involved with London Kalibari, leading and contributing to many musical functions our request. With her personal charm she made close friends with many people in London Kalibari and beyond in London. We send our condolences to her son, Saikat who lives in Harrow with his wife and two children.



মৃন্ময়ী কাকলী

মৃন্ময়ী কণ্ঠে তোলো গানের সুরে ভোরের তারে
কলকল ঝীর তারে 'আমি ক্যারিবের কাকলী চেনা শুনু।
কাকলী নামে পরিচিত হলে আমাদের কলকাকলীর মাঝে
পরিচিত হলে সবার মাঝে, নজরুল গেয়ার জন্য ও সুদূর।
নাইলে সান কত আসরে, পরিচিত হলে মৃন্ময়ী কুলে
ছোটো বয়স থেকে সবার মন তোমার সুমধুরে সুরে হলে।
দিব্য চেতনা পেয়েছে তোমায় দিব্য সাধনার কণ্ঠ হলে।
গেয়েছো তুমি দিব্য চেতনার সান অকুল সুরে হলে।
কাকলীর কলরব ভেসে এসেছে সুদূর সবার মাঝে সবার সুরে
আপনি করেছে তোমার নামের ডাকে তোমার আত্মীয়ের সাথে।
যখনই ডেকেছি তোমায় সুমধুর প্যারিস থেকে সান গাইতে
মনের আনন্দে চলে এসেছো আমাদের মাঝে সান শোনাতে।
কত আদর আপ্যায়ন করেছো সবাইকে মনের আনন্দে
আমরা ঋণি হয়ে দাঁড়ে পারি নই তোমার ভালবাসার ভাকে।
কৃষ্ণা ও বাবুদের সান গেয়েছো মনের আনন্দে সভার মাঝে
হলিত থেকে তোমার মৃন্ময়ী কণ্ঠ হলি তোমাদের মাঝে ফিরতে।
বি বেজাবলন ও মিলেদাতার সান উড়বুদ্ধ করেছে তোমার মন ভ্রমন
গেয়েছো আবেগের সুরে তাদের সান হয় করেছে সমাজের মান।
তোমার কণ্ঠটি সুমধুরে হলিত হয় আমাদের কানে জানে
তোমাকে রাখার আমাদের প্রানে স্থানে জীবন ফুরায় হলে।
কেন চলে গেলে আমাদের ছেড়ে অকালে ফিরদিনের তরে
আরো কিছুদিন দিতে আনন্দ তোমার মৃন্ময়ী সুরের সানে।
তোমার কণ্ঠ আজ বিশ্বব্যাপ্ত, ফিরবে না সেই সময়ের ফেলে
শুনব না আর তোমার মৃন্ময়ী কণ্ঠ আমাদের মাঝে ফিরতে।
প্রার্থনায় হলে সমাধীস্থ তুমি আজি ফিরতে
কাকলী বলে ডাকলে তোমায়, শুনব না আর তোমার মৃন্ময়ী সুরের সুর।
প্রার্থনা তোমায় ডাকিয়ে আমাদের মাঝে তোমার ঠিকানার সাথে
হে বন্ধু, নয় আজি আমাদের ভালবাসা তোমার এই মহাপ্রয়াণে।

6-2 ফেব্রুয়ারী 2019
শ্রীমৃণাল চৌধুরী

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Community Corner

Aloke Ray (son of our member Ratna). Aloke QC is partner and Co-Head of International Arbitration practice at White & Case, London. He represents clients in international arbitrations under the rules of major arbitral institutions. He was appointed Queen's Counsel by Her Majesty the Queen in March 2019. His educational qualifications are:
BA Jurisprudence, Oxford University, First Class Honours; M Phil Cambridge University;
LLP London College of Law, Distinction. We wish Aloke continuing success for the future.

Update from Dana (Shabnam Surita – Jayati's great niece). When I had the opportunity to visit Kalibari back in 2016, I didn't realise that a place of faith outside of India could evoke so much warmth and homely comfort for me. I was still new in figuring out how to find a balance between my Indian/Bengali roots and newfound European life. I first left home, in search of another one in 2015 when I came to Denmark as a Masters student. Studying South Asian Studies made it difficult to not miss everything that I had left behind. A part of me wanted to go back, but I prioritized my career choices over spats of homesickness and landed myself in Bonn, Germany. Here not only have I found myself discovering a larger meaning of being 'at home', but have also made one for myself. I am a Research Associate, Journalist and Social Worker all at once and try to help people find their way back into a community in all ways possible. In my free time, I try very hard to keep writing my PhD, my child in making. I mention all of this while remembering Kalibari to re-emphasize on the need for a supportive, tight community for people like me. Who have left something behind to move ahead in life and seek peace, faith and acceptance. For us diaspora Indians, Bengalis specifically, the notion of a Kalibari also evokes memories of long time ago. I look forward to visiting Kalibari again when I can and would take this opportunity to pass on my gratitude for having me there. I wish the people who keep the Kalibari running on an everyday basis more strength and hope to see the cause flourish leaps and bounds in the days to come.

Ajit Ghosh. We regret to announce the passing away of Ajit Ghosh on 21 October last year: he was associated with London Kalibari since its inception and for a time was its Vice President. We are thankful for his valuable contribution and we will miss him sorely. **Gnanamoy Banerjee**. We further regret the passing of Gnanamoy, husband of Bharati Banerjee, on 15 January of this year. We send our heartfelt condolences to both families.

Contacts:

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